

California's High-Stakes Primary: A Redistricting Reckoning

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California's bold **redistricting** gambit faces its first electoral test Tuesday, as a crowded primary in the San Diego suburbs threatens to derail Democratic hopes of flipping a key House seat. After Texas Republicans redrew their map to lock in up to five seats, California Democrats persuaded voters to suspend the state's independent **redistricting** commission and craft a retaliatory map. But the state's **top-two primary** system where the two highest vote-getters advance regardless of party could backfire spectacularly. In the 48th District, redrawn to have a slight Democratic lean, Republican Rep. Darrell Issa retired. GOP Supervisor Jim Desmond stepped in, **endorsed** by Trump. But nine Democrats also filed, sparking fears of a **vote split** that could allow Desmond and the only other Republican, Jim O'Neil, to claim both November spots. "After millions of dollars and a nationwide effort to redraw these districts in response to Texas, Democrats being shut out would be a nightmare," said Ammar Campa-Najjar, a former Obama official and Democratic candidate. The top Democratic contenders Campa-Najjar, Councilwoman Marni von Wilpert, and self-funding investor Brandon Riker are scrambling to consolidate support. The drama extends statewide. In the Central Valley, Republican Rep. David Valadao, one of two remaining House Republicans who voted to **impeach** Trump after January 6, faces a redrawn, more Democratic district. The primary will decide whether moderate Assemblywoman Jasmeet Bains or progressive professor Randy Villegas challenges him. In San Francisco, the race to succeed Nancy Pelosi features state lawmaker Scott Wiener against wealthy tech entrepreneur Saikat Chakrabarti, an early backer of Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, and Supervisor Connie Chan, **endorsed** by Pelosi. Other primaries test generational divides: 81-year-old Rep. Doris Matsui faces a young city council member, and 15-term Rep. Brad Sherman is challenged by a 42-year-old lawyer. In a redrawn Northern California district, 14-term Rep. Mike Thompson confronts a former **venture capitalist**. Republicans, too, are squeezed: Reps. Ken Calvert and Young Kim were drawn into the same conservative district, battling over Trump loyalty. The results will reveal whether California's **redistricting** retaliation pays off or becomes a cautionary tale.

Word Treasure

redistricting -- The process of redrawing the boundaries of voting districts, often done after a census or for political advantage.

top-two primary -- A system where all candidates compete in one primary, and the top two vote-getters advance to the general election, regardless of party.

vote split -- When multiple candidates from one party divide the vote, allowing a candidate from another party to win with fewer votes.

impeach -- To formally charge a public official with misconduct; here, referring to Trump's second impeachment after the January 6 attack.

endorsed -- Publicly supporting a candidate, often from influential figures like Trump or

Pelosi.

venture capitalist -- An investor who provides money to startup companies in exchange for equity; mentioned in the Northern California district race.

Background you need

Redistricting--the redrawing of voting maps--occurs every ten years after the U.S. census. In many states, the party in power manipulates lines to favor itself, a practice known as gerrymandering.

California's independent redistricting commission was created by a 2008 ballot measure to take map-drawing out of politicians' hands, but the state legislature can suspend it in rare circumstances, as they did this year.

The 'top-two' primary system, adopted by California voters in 2010, allows all candidates to run on a single ballot and sends the top two finishers to the general election--a system that sometimes produces two candidates from the same party.

David Valadao represents a Central Valley district and was one of ten House Republicans to vote for Trump's second impeachment after the January 6, 2021, assault on the Capitol, a vote that still divides his party.

Nancy Pelosi, who represented San Francisco for decades and became the first woman Speaker of the House, has endorsed Connie Chan in the primary to succeed her.

Break it down

LEAD: California's redistricting retaliation faces its first electoral test on Tuesday.

+ specific: The 48th District, redrawn to lean Democratic, sees crowded primary with nine Democrats.

KEY RISK: Top-two primary could split Democratic votes, letting two Republicans advance and shutting out Democrats.

+ WHO: Republican Rep. Darrell Issa retired; GOP candidates Desmond (Trump-endorsed) and O'Neil.

+ Democratic contenders: Campa-Najjar, von Wilpert, Riker scramble to consolidate.

STATEWIDE DRAMA: Other districts also face critical primaries.

+ CENTRAL VALLEY: David Valadao (impeachment voter) in a more Democratic district.

+ SAN FRANCISCO: Pelosi's open seat, with progressives vs. moderates.

+ GENERATIONAL DIVIDES: Older lawmakers like Doris Matsui face younger challengers.

REPUBLICAN SQUEEZE: Ken Calvert and Young Kim redrawn into the same district, loyalty battle.

OUTCOME: The primary will test whether California's redistricting strategy pays off or becomes a cautionary tale.

Why it matters

These primaries decide who appears on the ballot in November and can determine control of Congress--showing how a few thousand votes in a district can shape national laws on issues like climate, education, and digital rights that directly affect young people's futures.

Test what you remember

1. What is the main concern in the 48th District primary?
 - (A) Too many Republicans splitting the vote
 - (B) Too many Democrats splitting the vote
 - (C) Lack of candidates
 - (D) Low voter turnout
2. Which candidate is endorsed by Trump in the 48th District?
 - (A) Ammar Campa-Najjar
 - (B) Jim Desmond
 - (C) Marni von Wilpert
 - (D) Brandon Riker
3. Which Republican representative voted to impeach Trump after January 6?
 - (A) Darrell Issa
 - (B) David Valadao
 - (C) Ken Calvert
 - (D) Young Kim
4. Who is the wealthy tech entrepreneur running in San Francisco?
 - (A) Scott Wiener
 - (B) Saikat Chakrabarti
 - (C) Connie Chan
 - (D) Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez
5. What happened to Texas Republicans' map before California's response?
 - (A) They lost five seats
 - (B) They redrew their map to lock in up to five seats
 - (C) They disbanded their independent commission
 - (D) They switched to a top-two primary
6. What could happen if two Republicans advance from the 48th District?
 - (A) Democrats would automatically win another seat
 - (B) It would be a nightmare for Democrats who hoped to flip the seat
 - (C) It would trigger a runoff
 - (D) It would end the top-two system

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive:** Democrats believe the redrawn maps give them a fighting chance to flip districts and retake the House majority, potentially advancing their legislative agenda on climate and healthcare.
- 2. Negative / Critical:** The top-two system could backfire by locking out a major party from the general election, effectively disenfranchising Democratic voters in that district, raising concerns about the design of California's unique primary.
- 3. Neutral / Analytical:** Redistricting retaliation between states is a newer, high-stakes game: when one party gerrymanders aggressively, the other may respond in kind, potentially escalating to a national arms race of unfair maps that weakens voter representation overall.
- 4. Forward-looking:** If Democrats fail to advance in the 48th, it could spur a push to reform the top-two system or even overturn it, while success might encourage other states to adopt similar retaliatory tactics--both scenarios carrying long-term consequences for how elections are run and how moderate voices are heard.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):